

lowers celebrating (authorities charged) the murder of his rival. The prophet, from prison, issued a message to his flock:

TO THE HEADS OF ALL TEMPLES, ISLAM

I, your prophet, do hereby and now write you a letter as a warning and appeal to your good judgment for the present and the future. Though I am now in custody for you and the cause, it is all right and it is well for all who still believe in me and my father, God. I have redeemed all of you and you shall be saved, all of you, even me. I go to bat Monday, May 10, before the Grand Jury. If you are with me, be there. Hold on and keep faith, and great shall be your reward. Remember my laws and love ye one another. Prefer not a stranger to your brother. Love and truth and my peace I leave you all.

Peace from

Your Prophet

NOBLE DREW ALI

This proved to be Drew Ali's final official proclamation. Released on bond, he died under mysterious circumstances a few weeks later. One theory is that he succumbed to injuries inflicted by the police during his imprisonment, another is that he was set upon by partisans of Greene and beaten so severely that he never recovered.

After Drew Ali's death the prophet's attorney attempted unsuccessfully to hold the group together. Each among several of the prophet's disciples announced that he alone was the rightful inheritor of Drew Ali's leadership—each established a little temple of his own. More than one sought to lend additional weight to his claim by professing to be the reincarnation of the prophet.

The following quotations from a sermon by a minister of the Chicago Temple of Islam outline certain primary beliefs of the sect, founded in Detroit sometime before 1930 by a Negro peddler:

The Asiatic black man is the original man, the ruler of the universe, the eight inhabited planets and of this planet earth. Islam is the true religion. A religion which can be proved by mathematics in a limit of time.

The Moslems have the wisdom. We're not afraid of the devil, this so-called white man. We talk right up to them. They're afraid of you if you've got the Truth. Just tell 'em, "White man, you're a devil. You were grafted from the original black man." He'll say, "Yes, you're right." He'll admit it 'cause you got the power. Just say, "You're a beast, you've got one third animal blood." He won't deny it, 'cause it's true. When they

were driven from the Holy City of Mecca, they lived in the caves of Europe and mingled with the beasts.

Christianity is the religion of the so-called white man. Have you ever noticed that the very things he teaches us that the devil does is the very things he is doing? *He is the devil!*

"I am W. D. Fard," the peddler told those whom he sought to proselytize, "and I came from the Holy City of Mecca. More about myself I will not tell you yet, for the time has not yet come. I am your brother. You have not yet seen me in my royal robes."

He proclaimed that his mission was to secure "freedom, justice, and equality" for his "uncle" living in the "wilderness of North America, surrounded and robbed completely by the cave man." "The uncle of W. D. Fard" became a symbolical term for all Negroes of North America, while the white man was referred to as "a cave man," a "satan," or "Caucasian devil." Sometimes he would be called familiarly or contemptuously a "cavy" or "common ca."

Though Fard maintained that he was racially identical to North American Negroes, he was said to have been born in Mecca, the son of a wealthy member of the tribe of Koreish of which the Prophet Mohammed was a member. He was reputed to have been educated in England, or at the University of Southern California in Los Angeles; to have been trained for a diplomatic career in the service of the Kingdom of Hejaz. He has been described as light-colored, with an oriental cast of countenance.

Fard at times in his apocryphal career used various other names, among them Walli Farrad, Professor Ford, Farrad Mohammed, F. Mohammed Ali, and even the God Allah. He peddled silks and rain-coats from door to door in "Paradise Valley," the Negro neighborhood of Detroit. One of his converts said of him:

"He has told us that the silks he carried were the same kind that our people used in their home country, Arabia, and that he had come from there. So we all asked him to tell us about our own country. If we asked him to eat with us, he would eat whatever we had on the table, but after the meal he would begin to talk:

" 'Now don't eat this food. It is poison to you. The people in your own country do not eat it. Since they eat the right kind of food they have the best health all the time. If you would live just like the people in your home country, you would never be sick any more.' So we wanted him to tell us more about ourselves and about our

home country and about how we could be free from rheumatism, aches, and pains."

Fard began to arrange meetings in the homes of those willing to listen to him, and before long had gathered a small but devoted band of followers. His denunciations of the "white devil and his so-called spook civilization" became more and more virulent. His condemnation extended to the Christian religion, though he sometimes quoted from the Bible. In his *Secret Ritual of the Nation of Islam*, Part 2, Sec. II, Fard declared:

"Me and my people . . . have tried this so-called mystery God for bread, clothing, and a home. And we have received nothing but hard times, hunger, naked, and out of doors. Also was beat and killed by the ones that advocated that kind of God."

Most of Fard's converts had recently arrived from the South, and were inclined to agree with his contentions. Challar Sharrieff, formerly Charles Peoples, tells of hearing the prophet explain:

"The Bible tells you that the sun rises and sets. That is not so. The sun stands still. All your lives you have been thinking that the earth never moved. Stand and look toward the sun and know that it is the earth you are standing on which is moving."

"Up to that day," says Sharrieff, "I always went to the Baptist church. After I heard the sermon from the prophet, I was turned around completely. When I went home and heard that dinner was ready, I said:

" 'I don't want to eat dinner. I just want to go back to the meetings.' I wouldn't eat my meals, but I goes back that night and I goes to every meeting after that. Just to think that the sun above me never moved at all and that the earth we are on was doing all the moving. That changed everything for me."

The Negroes of Detroit could see all about them justification for Fard's accusations against the white man and his civilization. As the depression tightened its grip, numbers of them were laid off while white men were retained. In other instances, Negroes of long service were replaced by white newcomers. "Hard times, hunger, naked, and out of doors" assumed an immediate significance for the "original black men." When they were obliged to apply for public assistance, Negroes keenly felt the humiliation attached. It was not hard to convince them that they were the objects of special discrimination. Fard and his rapidly increasing band of disciples made considerable

hay in the Negro community. It has been estimated that eight thousand Detroit Negroes joined the cult during its first four years.

After Fard had succeeded in establishing permanent headquarters in the first Temple of Islam, he "registered" all the members, giving them "righteous" names to replace the "slave" names forced upon them by the "Caucasian devil." To obtain his "original" or "righteous" name, the applicant for membership in the Temple was required to write a letter to Fard (later to his successors) asking that he be rid of his "slave" name. While waiting for his "righteous" name the acolyte was designated by a simple "X." It was assumed that Fard (or his successor) knew the member's "righteous" name by virtue of the spirit of Allah within him. There were complications, however. At one time the prophet gave different surnames to three brothers. When confronted with this discrepancy, Fard explained that he had divined that the three new members were of different parentage.

The rapid growth of the first temple in Detroit was accompanied by the establishment of various subsidiary organizations. Chief of these was the University of Islam, to which the children of Detroit "Moslem" families were sent rather than to the public schools. At the university they were taught the so-called "knowledge of our own" as distinct from that of the "civilization of the Caucasian devils." Courses were given in "higher mathematics," astronomy, and what was termed "the general knowledge and ending of the spook civilization." All this specialized knowledge was deemed necessary to combat the "tricknology" learned by the "Caucasian devils" in their schools. The "higher mathematics" consisted of a variety of "problems" usually embodying a symbolical meaning and involving astronomical sums containing a dizzying number of digits. Several of these problems were read at each meeting of the cult as well as in classes of the University of Islam.

One problem reads:

"A lion, in a cage, walks back and forth sixty feet per minute, seeking a way out of the cage. It took him nearly four centuries to find the door. Now, with modern equipment, he is walking three thousand feet per minute and he has three thousand miles by two thousand miles to go yet.

"How long will it take him to cover this territory of said three

"How long will it take him to turn the whole seventeen million? Sixty minutes equals one hour, twenty-four hours equals one day, three hundred and sixty-five days equals one year. The above figures do not include rusty locks."

"What is the physical standard of a devil against the original?" another problem inquires. "How many ounces of brain does an original have? What is the exact percentage of tricknollogy used by the devil in the present so-called spook civilization? How long has the devil on the planet been using tricknollogy? Tell us how and who manufactured the devil."

[illegible]

"The uncle of W. D. Fard," states another problem, "lives in the wilderness of North America, surrounded and completely robbed by the cave man. He is working sixteen hours out of twenty-four hours for a very little pay. He has eight in his family to support, besides other little bills to meet each month. On top of that, a cave man came along and sold him an old touring car, which travels downhill at the rate of forty-eight miles per hour. If it is to be shown by actual test that a force of two hundred fifty pounds is required to maintain this rate on downhill speed, what horsepower must the engine deliver at the wheels? Thirty-three thousand pounds equals one horsepower."

At one time the attendance officers of the Board of Education of Detroit attempted to break up the University of Islam and to compel its students to return to the public schools. This precipitated violent resistance. Fearful of race riots, the courts released with suspended sentence almost all of the rioters.

More serious difficulties arose over the question of human sacrifice. It is said that Fard taught that it was the duty of every Moslem to offer as sacrifices four "Caucasian devils" in order that he might return to his home in Mecca. On November 21, 1932, the people of Detroit became acutely conscious of the presence of the cult through its first widely publicized human sacrifice. A prominent member, Robert Harris, renamed Robert Karriem, erected an altar in his home and invited his roomer, John J. Smith, to offer himself as a human sacrifice so that he might become "the Savior of the world." According to Harris, Smith agreed, and at the appointed hour for the sacrifice—9:00 A.M.—Harris plunged a knife into Smith's heart.

The next day the *Detroit Times* noted:

An Asiatic trend among Negro dole recipients of the Elmwood district, noted at the time as a passing whim, today came back with horror to two women welfare workers on learning that the fanatical Robert Harris had intended them for human sacrifice as infidels. . . . Harris stated to the police that each of these was a "no-good Christian," and that they would have been sacrificed if he knew where he could have found them.

In 1933 the Prophet of Islam had organized the Detroit temple so thoroughly that he himself was able to recede into the background, appearing very seldom to his followers during his final months in Detroit, and this mysterious aloofness fostered the belief that he was indeed the "Supreme Ruler of the Universe" or, as he had called himself, the God Allah.

Not all his followers, however, believed in Fard's divinity, and controversy over this was one of the several causes of dissension in the movement. As a direct consequence of an internal dispute, the Chicago branch of the Nation of Islam was established in the latter part of 1933 or early 1934.

In 1933 Fard left Detroit, disappearing altogether so far as any authoritative record is concerned. Some of his Detroit followers

immediately identified him with the God Allah, claiming that he had returned to the Holy City of Mecca. Others continued to regard him simply as their prophet. A split occurred, and that faction favorable to the deification of the cult's founder assumed "Temple People" as a name, severed all connections with the parent group, and eventually set up its headquarters in Chicago under Elijah Mohammed whose "slave" name had been Robert Poole. In September 1942 Elijah Mohammed and other members of the Chicago Temple of Islam were collared by the FBI and charged with evading the draft and influencing others to do so as well as maintaining seditious relations with the Japanese government. The latter indictment more or less petered out. The Islamites would be likely to gravitate toward any nation of colored people engaged in combat with the "Caucasian devil." Their aversion to registration of any sort antedated the war with Japan by several years.

Temple people have isolated themselves politically, economically, and socially from both white men and non-members of their own race. The economic confusion and upheaval attending the depression they explained by quoting Elijah Mohammed's assertion that the white man's rule of the world actually ended in 1914, and that Allah is preparing to wipe out this "spook civilization" which has been existing on borrowed time.

So the Islamites' refusal to register for the draft indicated no new tendency. Cult members have always been particularly virulent in their denunciations of Roosevelt and the New Deal. In their opinion, the WPA and all other alphabetical agencies were subtle efforts on the part of white men to save what is left of their dying civilization by getting "original" black men to sign up with them and be given a number. They eschew social-security numbers and relief-case numbers as manifestations of the "white devil's" aptitude in tricknollogy.

"Roosevelt," reads a piece of typewritten temple literature, "gave you a social-security number just to hold you and now he's getting ready to call in these numbers and give you a stamp. . . . He's going to put a stamp on you, the mark of the beast. You signed up with the devil and he gives you the filthy crumbs from his table like the rich man gave the man Lazarus."